

In what way does DoView Planning and outcomes theory apply to what AI systems do when they act in the world?

DoView Planning and outcomes theory were originally developed to conceptualize (in the case of outcomes theory) and provide practical tools (in the case of DoView Planning) for working with outcomes systems of any type. An outcomes system is any system that seeks to identify, prioritize, align, delegate, contract, implement, measure, attribute, or hold parties accountable for outcomes of any kind. Outcomes theory was designed as a generic theory that covers areas such as strategy, planning, management, implementation, delegation, contracting, performance measurement, evaluation, and reporting.

Before outcomes theory was developed, these areas were often theorized differently by various disciplines, including strategic planning, management, organizational development, accounting, policy analysis, program evaluation, economics, and operations research. The different professional language and diverse backgrounds led to people often 'talking past each other' and a lack of concise communication of best practice when working on outcomes in different contexts. In order overcome the differing professional languages related to outcomes, this DoView Planning and Practical Outcomes Theory Handbook provides over 100 tools that can be used by anyone in any profession when doing any strategy, planning, implementation, measurement, and management outcomes-related work.

Outcomes theory is 'agent neutral' regarding who or what is undertaking action to achieve outcomes. Its principles can apply to individuals, groups, organizations, policies, strategies, programs, and initiatives. With the rise of AI, humans are increasingly being joined by AI agents acting to achieve outcomes. Regardless of whether these AI agents are closely directed by humans or act autonomously, what they do is functionally analogous to human action in the world.

Given this, many principles of outcomes theory can apply equally to both humans and AI agents acting in the world. This 'Areas Where Outcomes Theory and DoView Planning May Apply to AI Agents Explainer (J1)' provides some examples of how outcomes theory and DoView Planning principles may be able to be used in regard to AI systems.

Source: DOVIEW PLANNING AND PRACTICAL OUTCOMES THEORY HANDBOOK (2025). DoView Planning.Org. Copyright Dr Paul W Duignan.